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Match to pay \$14M to the
FTC due to false
advertising and other
deceptive practices

Back in 2019, the U.S. Federal Trade Commission (FTC) [sued the dating app giant Match Group](#), accusing it of deceiving Match.com users into purchasing subscriptions through misleading means.

Now, after six years, the company — which operates popular dating apps Match, Tinder, OkCupid, Hinge, and Plenty of Fish — has agreed to a \$14 million settlement, as [announced](#) by the FTC on Tuesday.

The FTC stated that the \$14 million will be used to provide “redress to injured consumers.”

IMAGE CREDITS:

[According to the lawsuit](#), consumers were at risk of being scammed after the company sent marketing emails regarding new messages from senders it had already identified as likely bots or scammers, subsequently deceiving them into purchasing subscriptions while knowingly profiting from it.

Additionally, Match Group was accused of locking users out of their accounts after they attempted to dispute charges and kept their money without delivering the services they had paid for. The company was also accused of making it difficult for users to cancel their subscriptions.

Along with the \$14 million settlement, the proposed order requires Match Group to take several actions to address the issues.

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For instance, the company needs to clearly spell out the details of the six-month guarantee and ensure it doesn't take adverse actions against customers who raise billing issues. It also has to provide easy ways for users to cancel their subscriptions.

The settlement comes as the company continues to face criticism over how it handles trust and safety issues. The hope is that the proposed order will help improve the experience for users.

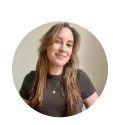
“As part of the agreement, Match.com and the other evergreen and emerging brands will continue to comply with ROSCA [Restore Online Shoppers' Confidence Act] and make a \$14 million payment, representing 5% of the FTC's monetary demand. Match Group admits no liability as part of this resolution and was fully prepared to take the case to trial, but opted to resolve the case to put the matter behind it. The FTC's outdated claims are entirely moot, as the alleged practices at issue ended years ago or are based on mischaracterizations that do not reflect our business today,” a company spokesperson said in a statement.

This story was updated to include a statement from Match Group.

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IMAGE CREDITS: PARADIGM

STARTUPS



Why Paradigm built a spreadsheet with an AI agent in every cell

Rebecca Szkutak — 8:00 AM PDT · August 18, 2025

Anna Monaco has been building AI agents since before the term “AI agents” was even a thing. After building numerous chatbots, she started looking for other types of interfaces that made sense for AI agents and landed on spreadsheets.

“I had this personal pattern, and I noticed that a lot of other people had this pattern, of putting very important CRM data in spreadsheets just because it

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was the most flexible thing,” Monaco told TechCrunch. “But it was actually a pain to maintain. There’s so much manual work involved. So [I] just went down this rabbit hole of building a product for myself and wanted to reimagine what a spreadsheet could look like with the full power of LLMs.”

The result was [Paradigm](#), an AI-powered spreadsheet equipped with more than 5,000 AI agents. Users can assign different prompts to individual columns and cells, and individual AI agents will crawl the internet to find and fill out the needed information.

Paradigm works with AI models from Anthropic, OpenAI, and Google’s Gemini, Monaco said, and supports model switching.

“We want to support every single model because we want our users to be able to have the highest reasoning outputs when they need it, but also the cheapest outputs,” Monaco said. “It’s just a constant cycle of evaluating different models, working closely with model providers to make sure our limits are high enough, and then giving some of that power to our users.”

The company launched a small closed beta preview in late 2024 and has been iterating on the product using customer feedback. Paradigm attracts users ranging from consultants to sales professionals and finance folks and operates on a subscription model with tiers based on usage. Paradigm counts the consulting firm EY, AI chip startup Etched, and AI coding company Cognition as early customers.

Paradigm is now releasing its product to the public and announcing that it raised a \$5 million seed round led by General Catalyst. The company has raised \$7 million to date. Monaco said the funding will go toward executing on the company’s “extremely aggressive product roadmap.”

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“The interesting thing that happened when we fundraised is some people we pitched just kept on using and paying for the product,” Monaco said. “I think that was a cool part of it. We found a lot of value from it internally and our investors, not even just our investors — other investors that we talked to — are still using it.”

Paradigm isn't the only company looking to give spreadsheets an AI upgrade. [Quadratic](#), which has

raised more than \$6 million in venture funding, is a 3-year-old startup with a similar goal. Legacy companies like Google and Microsoft are also adding AI tools to their spreadsheet applications.

Monaco said that she doesn't really consider the competition because Paradigm doesn't think of itself as an AI-powered spreadsheet. She said she thinks of it as a new AI-powered workflow that happens to be in the familiar form of a spreadsheet but won't necessarily stay that way forever.

"What I'm seeing in the most popular AI products now is this fine balance between present and future," Monaco said. "How do you build something that is really powerful and generates a lot of value now but also sets you up really well for the future? That's the question that I asked myself a year ago when I was starting the company."

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Rebecca Szkutak

Senior Reporter, Venture | [in](#)

Becca is a senior writer at TechCrunch that covers venture capital trends and startups. She previously covered the...

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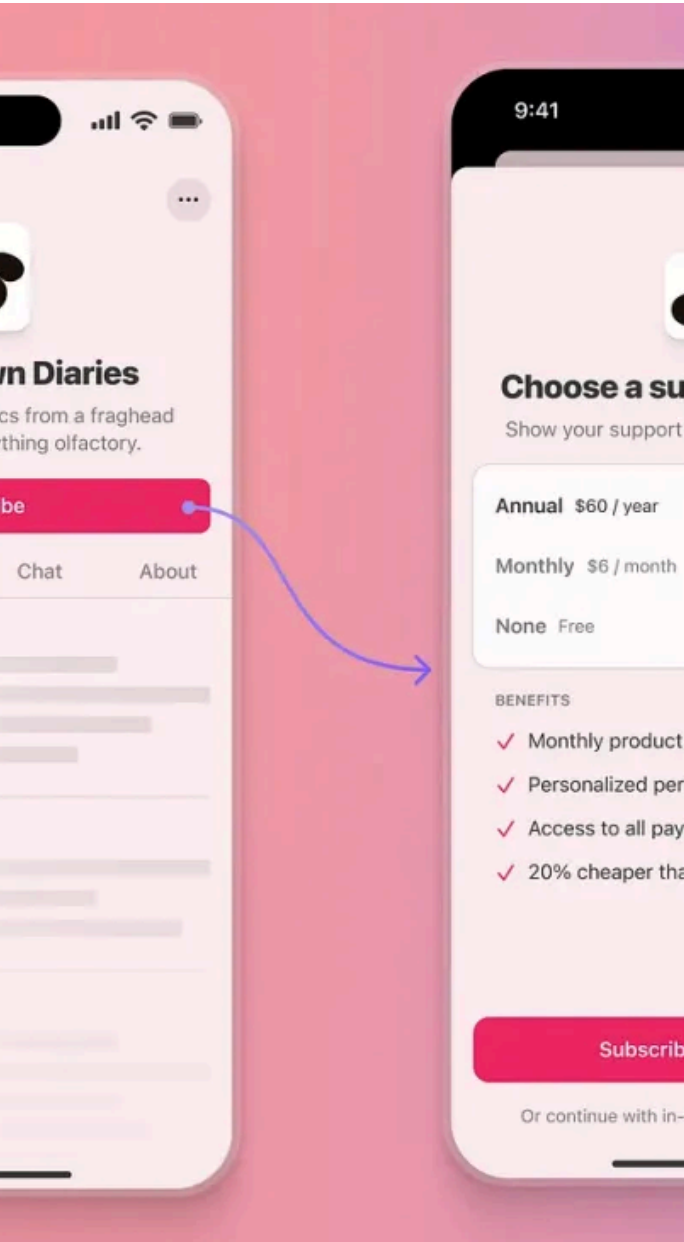


IMAGE CREDITS: SUBSTACK

APPS

Substack writers can now direct US readers to (often cheaper) web-based subscriptions on iOS

Sarah Perez — 10:16 AM PDT · August 18, 2025

Newsletter subscription platform Substack will begin taking advantage of an option on the U.S. App Store that allows users to make purchases outside of Apple's in-app purchasing system. This functionality is permitted by a [change to the App Store's rules in May](#), as a result of [Epic Games' antitrust lawsuit](#) against the tech giant.

Since then, a number of top apps have moved to offer in-app purchase links that point to their own websites, including [Spotify](#), [Patreon](#), and the [Amazon Kindle](#) app, among others.

In Substack's case, support for external payments will benefit both the company, which no longer has to pay the App Store a commission on those web sales, and consumers, who will have access to reduced pricing. Meanwhile, Substack creators will be able to offer their readers the option of whether they want the convenience of Apple's in-app payments system (IAP) or the web payment option, which is now accessible without having to leave the app.

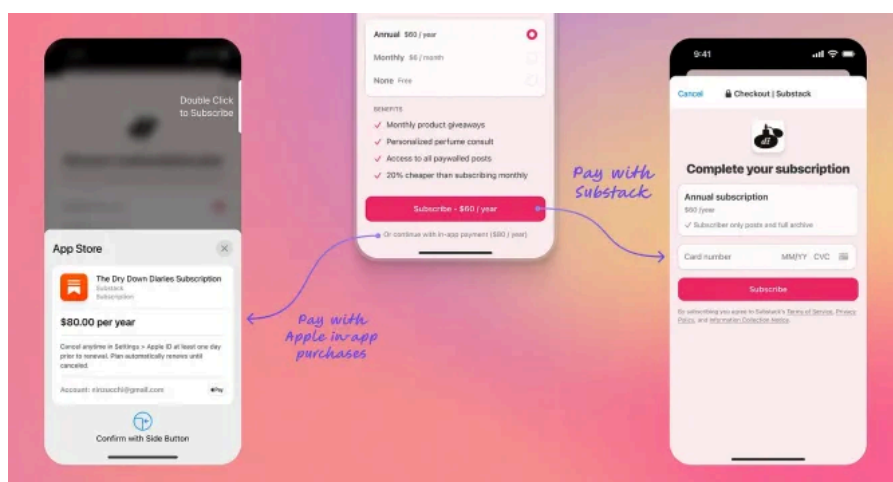


IMAGE CREDITS: SUBSTACK

Substack explains it will automatically adjust its customers' iOS app price higher to account for Apple's fees, allowing creators to take home the same amount of money as a web subscription. However, Substack writers can disable this feature if they choose. (Substack will continue to take its own

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Aisha Malik - 3 hours ago

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Sarah Perez - 6 hours ago

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Ivan Mehta - 12 hours ago

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10% fee based on the web subscription price, as before.)

The company said in its blog post that it's also offering its writers "migration tools." We originally reported that these could help migrate users from one payments platform to another, but Substack reached out to correct this. Instead, it said that the tools are meant to help creators access billing information for Apple-managed subscriptions if they ever leave the platform.

Currently, more than 30,000 publications on the platform have in-app purchases enabled; Substack says early tests of the expanded set of payment options have driven a boost in paid sign-ups. It did not, however, share specific numbers related to this.

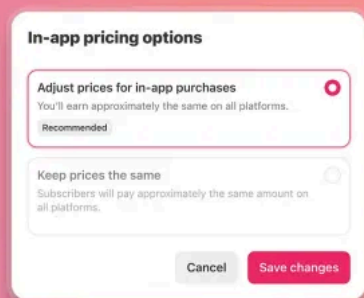


IMAGE CREDITS: SUBSTACK

The public launch of the external payments option will only impact new Substack subscriptions. Substack writers don't have to take any action unless they want to lower the prices for those using Apple's payments system.

Per Apple's App Store rules, fully opting out of offering IAP is not allowed.

While the changes impact the Substack app in the U.S., the company says it's still evaluating if it makes sense to switch to the more complex rules Apple

offers in the EU and U.K. for developers who want to forgo IAP.

Updated after publication to correct and clarify how the migration tools work.

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Sarah Perez

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Sarah has worked as a reporter for TechCrunch since August 2011. She joined the company after having...

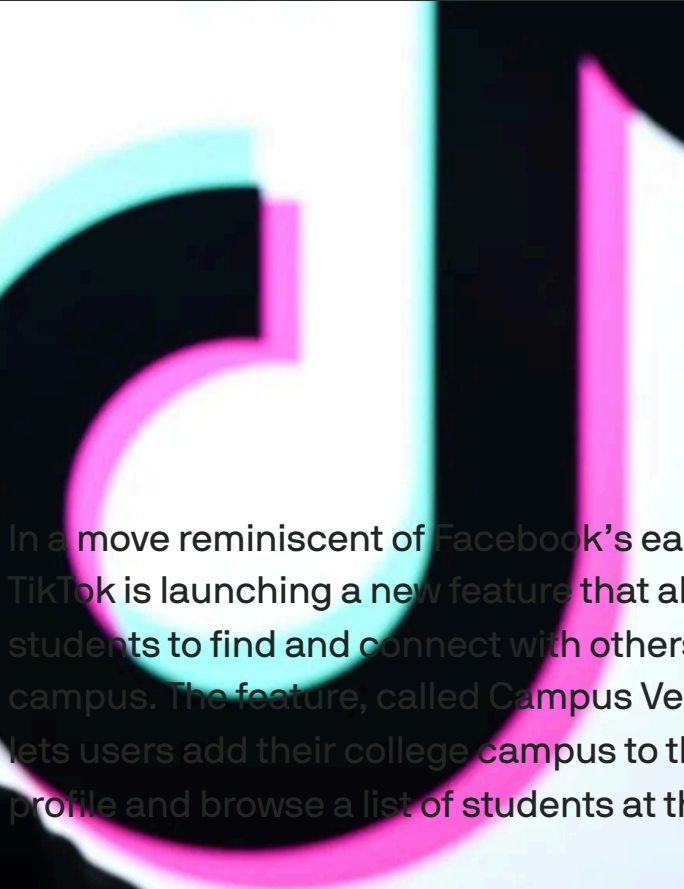
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Aisha Malik — 6:00 AM PDT · August 19, 2025



In a move reminiscent of Facebook’s early days, TikTok is launching a new feature that allows college students to find and connect with others on their campus. The feature, called Campus Verification, lets users add their college campus to their TikTok profile and browse a list of students at their school.

To access the feature, users need to navigate to their profile and tap the “Add school” button. From there, they need to enter their school name and then select their graduation year.

To verify that they actually go to the school they entered, they need to provide their academic email address. Once complete, their college name and graduation year will be displayed on their profile.

Users can then browse their school’s page, filter by graduation year, and view all of the users who have added the school to their profile. They can also sort the users list to show the most-followed users first.

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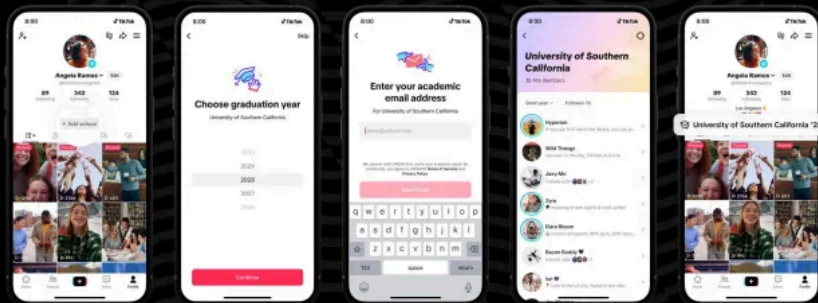
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TikTok

IMAGE CREDITS:TIKTOK

The feature is available across more than 6,000 universities through TikTok’s partnership with [UNiDAYS](#), a student verification platform that confirms student status.

TikTok says the idea behind the feature is to turn its platform into a hub for real-world connections and belonging on campus, which is essentially what Facebook’s original mission was when it launched in 2004 as a way for Harvard students to connect with one another.

TikTok’s new feature could be a welcome addition for college students looking to connect with others on campus. However, it also raises concerns about digital privacy, as it could make it easier for users to track others online. Of course, the feature is optional, so those who prefer to keep their TikTok presence separate from their student life can choose to simply not add their school to their profile.

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It's worth noting that the launch comes as Instagram was [spotted testing a similar feature](#) last year that would allow users to display their school info and graduation year on their profile and connect with other students. It's unknown if the feature was scrapped or if the Meta-owned platform still plans to roll it out.

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Aisha Malik

Consumer News Reporter | [X](#) [Twitter](#) [in](#)

Aisha is a consumer news reporter at TechCrunch. Prior to joining the publication in 2021, she was a telecom reporte...

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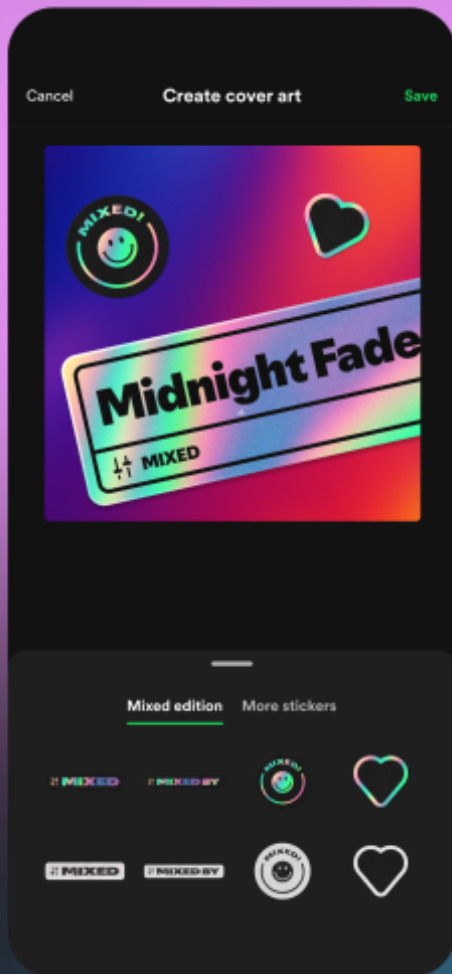


IMAGE CREDITS: SPOTIFY

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Spotify's latest feature lets you add your own transitions to playlists

Sarah Perez — 3:00 AM PDT · August 19, 2025

Spotify is [introducing](#) a new feature that allows subscribers to create more professional, personalized playlists. On Tuesday, the company launched a custom transitions feature that lets you either automatically add transitions between a

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playlist's tracks or customize your own using preset options like fade, rise, or blend, along with other options.

To use the feature, open any playlist and select “Mix” from the toolbar to begin editing. While customizing the track with different transition styles, you can also adjust settings for things like the volume, EQ, and effects, and use the waveform and beat data to find the best spot in each track to begin the transition.

Spotify notes that it will automatically display the key and the beats per minute for each track, to make it easier for novice audio mixers to get started.

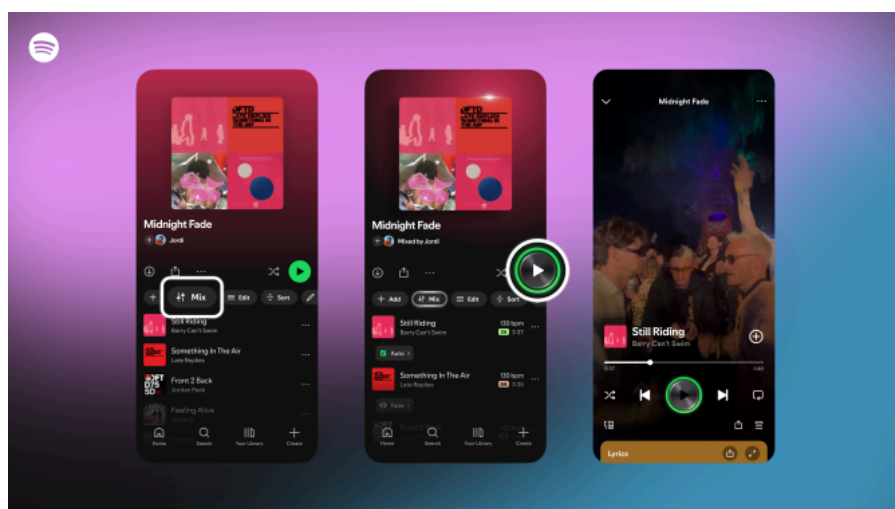


IMAGE CREDITS: SPOTIFY

The new options are designed to appeal to playlist experts and other music fans, who have collectively created nearly 9 billion playlists on Spotify's platform to date.

The rollout complements other updates Spotify has launched over the past year that give users more control over their listening experience, the company says, like the tools to [add, sort, and edit playlists](#), [customize the genre of the Discover Weekly](#) playlist, [snooze tracks](#), [make voice requests to the AI DJ](#), and more. It also allows Spotify to compete with Apple Music's [upcoming](#) AutoMix feature, which is currently live in the iOS 26 developer beta, and claims to let you mix “like a DJ.”

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Premium subscribers with access to the transitions feature will also be able to save and share the playlist with other friends on social media or even invite other subscribers to collaborate on a mixed playlist.

The mix can be toggled on and off at any time by pressing the “mix” option, allowing you to turn your playlist back to the more traditional kind when the party or gym workout (or wherever else you’re streaming the mix) has ended.

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IMAGE CREDITS: SPOTIFY

The company recommends that mixing works best with music that's already been produced for seamless transitions, like house and techno, which tend to blend more easily.

Like other playlists, the mixes can be further [customized using your own cover art](#) along with newly added stickers and labels made just for mixed playlists.

Custom transitions in playlists are available starting today for the majority of eligible Premium users worldwide. (The company says some markets in the APAC region will still need to wait for the addition.) The feature is rolling out gradually to users who have updated their Spotify app for iOS or Android.

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